

RESEARCH REPORT

Gambling Problems in Bulgaria

A 10-Year Statistical Overview (2014–2025)

March 2025

Key Statistics at a Glance

~200,000+ Estimated addicts 3% of population (govt. est.)	37% Helpline peak share % of addiction calls in 2022	50,000+ Self-excluded persons Registered with NRA by 2026
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1. Introduction & Background

Bulgaria has experienced a dramatic expansion of its gambling industry over the past decade, transitioning from a tightly controlled market to one of the most liberalised in the European Union. While the industry contributes substantially to national tax revenues, this growth has been accompanied by an equally sharp rise in gambling-related harm, addiction, and social costs.

This report consolidates available statistics from Bulgarian government agencies, the National Revenue Agency (NRA), the Solidarnost Association's national helpline (NILNAH), the European School Survey Project on Alcohol and Other Drugs (ESPAD), and investigative journalism sources covering the period 2014–2025. It is intended as a research reference for academics, policymakers, and public health professionals.

Important caveat: Bulgaria has never conducted a nationally representative prevalence survey on gambling addiction. All figures cited here derive from voluntary self-exclusion registers, helpline call data, and selective studies. Actual rates of problem gambling are almost certainly higher than recorded.

2. Scale of Gambling Addiction

2.1 Population-level estimates

Multiple sources provide estimates of the gambling-addicted population in Bulgaria:

- Government estimate: More than 200,000 Bulgarians — approximately 3% of the total population — have some form of gambling addiction (Novinite.com / European Gaming, ~2023).
- Research estimate (Bulgarian Academy of Sciences / Prevention Association): Between 4% and 7% of the adult population (approximately 280,000 to 490,000 people) suffer from gambling addiction.
- Registered self-excluded persons (NRA register): 41,344 by end-2024; exceeding 50,000 by early 2026.
- A key methodological note: registered individuals represent only those who voluntarily self-identify. Experts universally regard the register as a severe undercount.

2.2 Self-exclusion register trend (NRA)

The NRA's Vulnerable Persons Register — a voluntary self-exclusion tool — provides the clearest longitudinal signal of growing problem gambling, though it was suspended between December 2020 and December 2022 due to legislative changes:

Period	New Registrations	Notes
Dec 2022 (1 month)	125	Register reinstated after 2-year suspension
Full year 2023	27,720	Explosive growth following relaunch
Jan – Nov 2024	21,435	Continued rapid uptake
Cumulative by end-2024	41,344	Total registered; 8,120 removed
Cumulative by early 2026	50,000+	Based on reported projections

The minimum self-exclusion period was extended from 30 days to one full year in March 2025, reflecting legislative recognition of the inadequacy of shorter exclusions.

3. The Helpline Data: A Decade of Rising Calls

The most granular longitudinal trend comes from the National Information Line on Narcotics, Alcohol and Gambling (NILNAH), operated by the Solidarnost Association. Their data tracks the share of all addiction-related calls attributable to gambling:

Year	Gambling calls (% of total)	Trend
Until 2013	1–2%	Baseline
2014	~3%	Gradual rise begins
2016	8%	Notable increase
2017	~11%	Sharp jump

Year	Gambling calls (% of total)	Trend
2019	~16%	Continued growth
2020	18%	COVID-era acceleration
2021	27%	Rapid surge
2022	37%	Peak – surpasses alcohol
2023	34%	Slight decrease, remains dominant

By 2022, gambling had become the single most cited addiction on the national helpline, surpassing alcohol — a remarkable shift from just a decade earlier. People sought help for gambling problems more frequently than for any other substance or behavioural addiction. The COVID-19 pandemic (2020–2021) appears to have been a major inflection point, with restrictions on land-based venues accelerating migration to online platforms and intensifying problem gambling.

4. Youth and Adolescent Gambling

Young people represent one of the most vulnerable groups for problem gambling in Bulgaria, with several alarming findings:

4.1 High school students

- A Bulgarian government study found that as many as 12% of all high school students are problem gamblers (OCCRP / The Uncontrollable Urge investigation).
- Bulgaria is described as having one of the highest rates of underage gambling in the EU, a pattern shared with neighbouring Balkan countries.

4.2 ESPAD 2024 findings (EU-wide school survey)

The 2024 European School Survey Project on Alcohol and Other Drugs provides comparative EU data for 15–16 year-old students:

Indicator	Bulgaria	EU Average (ESPAD)
Students gambling online (% of those who gambled)	74%	65%
EU ranking for online youth gambling	Joint 1st (with Slovakia)	—
Students w/ harmful gambling profile (2024)	~8.5% (EU avg)	8.5%

Indicator	Bulgaria	EU Average (ESPAD)
Students w/ harmful gambling profile (2019)	~4.7% (EU avg)	4.7%
Online gambling – boys (2024)	20%	20%
Online gambling – girls (2024)	8.7%	8.7%

The proportion of student gamblers exhibiting a potentially harmful gambling profile nearly doubled between 2019 and 2024 across Europe, and Bulgaria's high participation in online gambling places its young people at elevated risk.

5. Market Growth and Industry Context

The expansion of Bulgaria's gambling market is the structural driver of addiction growth. Understanding market scale helps contextualise the social harm statistics:

5.1 Tax revenue from gambling (NRA data)

Year	Tax Revenue (BGN million)	Change
2020	BGN ~193M	Baseline post-reform
2021	BGN 241M	+25% year-on-year
2022 (9 months only)	BGN 233M	Annualised ~310M
Jan–Sep 2023	BGN 286M	Continued growth
2024 estimate	BGN 392M	+37% vs 2023

For context: the online gambling sector alone is valued at €561 million (BGN 1.1 billion), and total market revenues (land-based + online) are estimated at over \$820 million in 2025. The number of licensed online operators grew from 6 in 2020 to 22 by 2024, following the removal of the dominant operator Vasily Bozhkov's companies.

5.2 Gambling industry growth figures

- BGN 3 billion (~€1.5 billion): estimated total net worth of the Bulgarian gambling industry.
- BGN 320 million: scratchcard company revenue in 2016, up 30% from the prior year.
- BGN 5.79 billion disbursed to winning players in 2023 — a 147% increase from 2022's BGN 2.34 billion (NRA data via Mediapool FOIA request).
- Online sports betting and online casino segments projected to grow at 12% and 30% annually respectively.
- 4.9% user penetration in online gambling estimated for 2024; 441,600 users projected by 2029.

6. Financial & Social Impact

6.1 The gambling-debt cycle

A critical social dynamic has emerged linking gambling addiction to the rapid-loan ("бързи кредити") sector:

- Bulgarian National Bank data: receivables of quick-loan companies reached BGN 6.017 billion in H1 2024, up 22% from BGN 4.926 billion in H1 2023 — a BGN 1.09 billion increase in one year.
- A significant but unquantified share of these loans are taken by gambling addicts seeking to cover losses — creating a debt trap.
- As of May 2025, there are 255 pawn shops in Bulgaria — a 4.51% increase from 2023 — partially linked to gambling-related financial distress.

6.2 Treatment gap

Despite the scale of the problem, treatment provision in Bulgaria is severely limited:

- Bulgaria devotes no gambling tax revenue directly to addiction treatment (OCCRP investigation finding).
- There is no national Ministry of Health programme specifically for gambling disorder treatment.
- Operators are required to pay annual "social responsibility" fees (BGN 50,000 for online betting operators), but the destination of these funds was not transparent — the Bulgarian Gambling Association itself noted it could not determine where the money went.
- The 2023–2025 National Youth Programme under the Ministry of Youth and Sport includes gambling-related measures, but none directly addressing addiction treatment.

7. Regulatory Timeline (2014–2025)

Year	Regulatory Development
2012	Gambling Act enacted — legalises land-based and online gambling; NRA becomes primary regulator
2016	Scratchcard revenues surge 30% YoY; aggressive marketing campaigns noted
2020	State Gambling Commission dissolved amid corruption allegations; NRA takes full control; self-exclusion register suspended (Dec)
2021	Online lotteries placed under state monopoly

Year	Regulatory Development
2022 (Dec)	Self-exclusion register reinstated after 2-year gap
2023	NRA Anti-Money Laundering (AML) unit established; Gambling Act amended
2024 (Apr)	Bulgarian Parliament unanimously votes to ban gambling advertising on TV, radio, print, and websites (effective May 2024)
2024	Tax rate for online operators increased from 15% to 20% of gross gaming revenue
2025 (Mar)	Minimum self-exclusion period extended from 30 days to 1 year
2025	'You Are Not Alone' campaign launched by NRA + Customs Agency targeting youth
2026 (Jan)	Tax rate set to increase further to 25% of gross gaming revenue

8. Summary Data Table

Indicator	Statistic	Source / Year
Population with gambling addiction (govt.)	~200,000 / ~3% of pop.	European Gaming / NRA, ~2023
Population with addiction (research est.)	4–7% of adults (280K–490K)	BAN / Prevention Association
Self-excluded persons in NRA register	41,344 (end-2024); 50,000+ (2026)	NRA data via Dnes.bg / Banker.bg
New NRA registrations, 2023	27,720	NRA official data
New NRA registrations, Jan–Nov 2024	21,435	NRA official data
Helpline gambling calls (2013)	1–2% of all addiction calls	Solidarnost / NILNAH
Helpline gambling calls (2022 peak)	37% of all addiction calls	Solidarnost / NILNAH
Helpline gambling calls (2023)	34%	Solidarnost / NILNAH
High school students problem gamblers	~12%	Bulgarian government study (OCCRP)
Online gambling – youth (ESPAD 2024)	74% of gamblers use online (EU: 65%)	ESPAD 2024
Gambling tax revenue (2021)	BGN 241M (~€123M)	NRA / industry report
Gambling tax revenue (2024 est.)	BGN 392M (~€200M)	China-CEE Institute
Online gambling sector value	€561M (BGN 1.1 billion)	Kapital / betConsultants

Indicator	Statistic	Source / Year
Total market revenue (2025 est.)	~\$820M	iGamingToday
Licensed online operators (2024)	22 (up from 6 in 2020)	betConsultants
Quick loans to consumers (H1 2024)	BGN 6.017 billion (+22% YoY)	Bulgarian National Bank

9. Research Limitations & Gaps

Researchers and officials have consistently flagged several critical gaps in Bulgaria's gambling harm data:

- No national prevalence study: Bulgaria has never conducted a nationally representative survey quantifying gambling addiction rates, demographic breakdown, or onset age. This is a fundamental gap in European comparison.
- Voluntary register undercount: The NRA self-exclusion register captures only those who self-identify. The true population of problem gamblers is estimated to be many times higher.
- No treatment tracking: There is no systematic data on treatment uptake, recovery rates, or treatment-seeking behaviour among problem gamblers.
- Financial harm data absent: No official statistics link gambling to personal bankruptcy, household debt, or family breakdown — though anecdotal and partial evidence (rapid-loan data) strongly suggests significant financial harm.
- Youth data lag: The ESPAD survey is conducted every 4–5 years. Between waves, there is no systematic monitoring of youth gambling behaviour.
- Gender and demographic breakdown: Existing statistics are poorly disaggregated by gender, age, income, or region, limiting targeted intervention design.

10. Sources

The following primary and secondary sources were used in compiling this report:

- National Revenue Agency of Bulgaria (NRA) — nra.bg — self-exclusion register data, tax revenue figures, licensing statistics
- Solidarnost Association — NILNAH (National Information Line on Narcotics, Alcohol and Gambling) — helpline call statistics 2013–2023
- ESPAD 2024 — European School Survey Project on Alcohol and Other Drugs — European Union Drugs Agency (EUDA) — euda.europa.eu
- China-CEE Institute — 'The Vicious Circle of Gambling Addiction and Quick Loan Companies' — china-cee.eu, 2025
- Capital.bg — 'Gambling: The Bright Future of Bulgaria' (Apr 2024); 'Bulgaria is Drowning in Gambling Addiction' (Jul 2025)

- Dnes.bg / 168chasa.bg — '41,344 Bulgarians have declared themselves addicted to gambling' (Dec 2024)
- OCCRP — 'The Uncontrollable Urge' — investigative series on Balkan gambling — occrp.org
- Novinite.com — 'Gambling Addiction Affects 3% of Bulgaria's Population' — Sofia News Agency
- betConsultants.net — 'Bulgaria's Gambling Sector Sees Significant Growth' (Oct 2024)
- iGamingToday — 'Bulgaria iGaming Market Research Report' (Aug 2025)
- InsideBitcoins — 'Bulgarian Gambling Industry Thrives Amid Tax Reforms' (Dec 2024)
- Bulgarian National Bank — Quick loan receivables data, H1 2024
- Banker.bg — 'Risk Loses, Risk (Doesn't) Win — The Major Gambling Addiction' (Jan 2026)

— *End of Report* —